around it a different colour, so that an overflying craft can spot it and we can send boats to recover it.

Pilot Krishnan flew the Pushpak. The probe's descent was filmed. Watching the probe descend for a full fifteen minutes was as strenuous as boring. So we decided to watch the video later to analyse every movement. There was a problem—we did not have a projector room. So off we went, a score of scientists, to Central Theatre, a cinema hall in the heart of Trivandrum that my cousin R Subbiah owned, to watch the recovery experiment. The film, however, turned out to be a damp squib. Mathew, our only photographer who designated himself the chief photographer, did not appear to believe in using the zoom facility of the camera. The result—grainy visuals of a speck floating down the sky. We did not make an issue of it since we were too happy with the grand success of our first recovery system.

A recovery system is imperative for manned missions for the simple reason that we need to get the men and women back to earth after the space flight. Space agencies including ISRO are working on such recovery systems also to reuse some of the rocket parts to save money. When it is not a manned flight, all that has to be considered is if a recovery system is cost-effective. Rocket parts that fall into the sea after each stage separation are no doubt precious, but integrating a recovery system into the rocket means adding to its weight. The thumb rule is that for every 16 kg you add to a stage, the payload weight goes down by 1 kg, which means a lot of money when it comes to satellites with costly transponders and cameras.

Sometime in the 2000s, ISRO did a recovery experiment from the Sriharikota launch facility. I felt sad that not a word was spoken about Sudhakar who conceived the idea and delivered on it almost forty years earlier. Not so surprising, as it comes from an organisation which has done precious little to remember Vikram Sarabhai beyond naming the space centre in Trivandrum after him.